

HOUSEWIVES: A OR B?

Much of the variation in gift giving among different children can be explained by occupation (or socioeconomic status) and gender. We have found that housewives have the highest propensity of all major occupational groups to receive inheritances as well as periodic financial gifts from their parents (see [Tables 6-1](#) and [6-2](#)). In fact, housewives are three times more likely to receive substantial inheritances from their parents than are adult children of the affluent on average. In essence, housewives rank first in both the size of their inheritances and the incidence of inheriting wealth from their parents. They are also most likely to receive significant financial gifts on an annual basis.

We have identified two distinct types of housewife-daughters of the affluent—we’ll call them Type A and Type B. Both benefit to different degrees from their parents’ beliefs that nonworking women must have “money of their own,” that the economic deck is stacked against women, and that sons-in-law can never be fully trusted to provide support for their wives and children.

The Type A housewife differs significantly from her Type B counterpart. Type As tend to marry high-income-producing, successful men. They tend to take leadership roles in caring for their elderly, sometimes disabled, parents. The gifts and inheritance they tend to receive are, in part, compensation for these efforts—efforts their working brothers and sisters are more likely to shy away from. Type A housewives are well educated and tend to be the executrixes or co-executors of their parents’ estates. They are likely to be leaders and volunteers in various local educational and charitable organizations.

TABLE 6-1
THE LIKELIHOOD OF RECEIVING A SUBSTANTIAL INHERITANCE:
OCCUPATIONAL CONTRASTS AMONG THE ADULT CHILDREN OF
THE AFFLUENT

LIKELIHOOD OF RECEIVING AN INHERITANCE

Significantly More Likely	Significantly Less Likely	About Average
• Housewife • Unemployed	• Physician • Senior Manager/Executive	• Engineer/Architect/Scientist • Advertising/Marketing/Sales Professional